

Understanding the practice of 'mindless' scrolling on TikTok in the context of pandemic life and social acceleration

Introduction: Why TikTok?

- Short video app; available internationally since around 2017; 1 billion users worldwide.
- Negative and patronising reporting on the app; image of it being an ultimate 'time wasting machine' (e.g. Odell 2019).
- Case to understand the consequences of 'addictive' media and practices such as scrolling on people's wellbeing.

Overview of the study

- Grounded in ethnographic tradition of audience studies focussed on the ritual and everyday contexts of media use (cf. Hermes 1995, Lull 1990, Morley 1986, Silverstone 1994, among others).
- 6 months of digital ethnography on TikTok to gain contextual understanding (see Schellewald 2021).
- Series of semi-structured interviews over 1 year with 30 young adults based in UK (Summer 2020 to Summer 2021).

The TikTok For You Page

- Content feed sitting at the heart of the app; central site of communicative interaction (mediated by algorithm).
- Form of communication on For You Page strongly marked by mimetics (see Schellewald 2021 or Zulli and Zulli 2020).
- Videos not experienced as discrete texts but assemblage/flow of videos materialising a personalised 'structure of feeling' (Williams 1974, 1977).

The pleasures of 'passive' consumption

- TikTok appealed to young adults in moments of anxiety, stress, pressure, tiredness, or boredom as site of momentary escape.
- Decision for TikTok within polymedia environment (Madianou and Miller 2012) was almost always to avoid senses of pressure to interact and perform experienced on other platforms.
- For You Page described as something 'ready-to-hand'. Very easy to just scroll without having to think or do anything on the app itself.

Dealing with TikTok's 'addictive' design

- Addictive design creates constant sense of anticipation for more; new and potentially better content is just one swipe away.
- Algorithm-user relationship not one-sided domination but process of 'mutual domestication' (cf. Siles et al. 2019).
- People actively engaged with app because of 'addictiveness'; not blindly falling into algorithmic trap but have self-awareness.

Understanding algorithms as popular culture

- Audience studies offers fuller view on the consequences and outcomes of 'addictive' design; distraction and 'mindlessness' can also be actively sought states (cf. Paasonen 2016).
- People are not 'free' in how they can use apps, appropriate them, or negotiate their consequences. There are limits, however, there also always is room for 'exploitation' by users.
- Seeing algorithms as contradictory forms: both mechanisms of control and sources of meaning; popular culture is always a site marked by a struggle over meaning (cf. Hall 1981, Martin-Barbero 1993)